1980s the military co-opted organised Buddhism as the state religion.[20] In the absence of a homogeneous ethnic identity for much of the population of the country, they increasingly resorted to seeing Buddhism as the essential criterion for being a 'true Burmese', as they set about nation-building. In the early years of military rule, Buddhism was secondary to the ideology of the 'Burmese Road to Socialism', but it was nonetheless important to the military as a source of legitimacy. Later, monasteries, which had fallen into disrepair under the British, were restored, and grants awarded to support monks.[21] By supporting the Buddhist hierarchy, the generals claimed they were fulfilling the Theravada expectations of just rulers.

The establishment of military rule did nothing to bring an end to the series of military campaigns aimed at the hill tribes in the northern, eastern and southern borders, and this situation, over time, led to substantial human rights abuses and the creation of a large refugee problem. Typical of this was the plight of the Karen people. By 1990, over 31,000 had been displaced into refugee camps in Thailand and left totally dependent on foreign aid,[22] and many others were internally displaced within Burma. Their situation was made worse by military cooperation between the Burmese and Thai regimes, ostensibly in an attempt to curb heroin production and export,[23] but in reality aimed at imposing central control over a region that had become de facto independent of both states. Indeed, there is evidence that both the regime and armed opposition groups used the production and export of drugs to fund the conflict.[24] Equally, both the military and the various hill tribes have made regular use of child soldiers:[25] every faction in the wars that have scarred Myanmar since 1948 are guilty in this respect.[26] All this adds to the mindset of the military that the entire nation forms a potential threat to its existence. This has continued to the present day where the army presents ongoing inter-communal violence as a fundamental reason why they cannot relinquish full power to the ostensibly democratic institutions now in place.[27]

In 1974 Burma's constitution was formally changed to that of a one-party state, entrenching army rule, though notionally through the civilian Burma Socialist Programme Party.[28] Subsequently, the leadership of the army became increasingly divorced from the country it ruled. Relatively pampered, it captured most of the wealth and increasingly came to see the rest of society as a threat to its order.[29] By this stage, the military's rule was